All of this is supplemented by a truly worldwide constituency when it comes to multilateral outcomes and global issues. Voting patterns of nations are often characterized by blocs and India's appeal is accordingly targeted. This complex picture underlines how much more layered foreign policy calculations have become in this day and age. A large nation and a rising power certainly cannot visualize its strategy in linear terms or with limited variables. And the beauty of our differentiated world is that everybody is pursuing their own matrix.

The commentary that accompanied the expansion of BRICS in South Africa in August 2023 merits some observations. Much of it suggested that the US specifically, and the West generally, were the elephants in the room. The truth, in fact, was very different. The outcomes were an intricate negotiation to find common ground among the powers that were actually there. Each one of them had their own reasons to chart an independent path and there were overlaps between them. The six invited states (Saudi Arabia, UAE, Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia and Argentina) all have strong and established relationships with India, as indeed with other BRICS members. Their own inclinations are very much towards multipolarity.

The occasion also saw a groundswell of pressure on the UNSC reform, which, therefore, led to a significant evolution in the collective BRICS position. That both current and potential members have a shared interest in promoting trade settlements in their national currencies was another point of convergence. The bottom line is that the international system is today headed in more independent and multiple directions. Viewing it exclusively through an anti-Western prism would be misleading.

A POST-COVID WORLD

As challenging as the long view is, nothing really prepared us for the enormity of the Covid pandemic. It was not the human toll that it took, which alone was mind-boggling. The disruption it caused to the routine was just beyond imagination. The reason for this was that the last time something similar took place, the world was not as tightly connected as we are today. The difference between the Spanish Flu and Covid is a statement about the evolution of global society. They influence our expectations of an effective response, as they do of the benefits of international cooperation.